

CHAPTER ONE

What Are the Foundations of Politics?



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LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- 1 Become familiar with the basic foundations of politics:
 - Political theory
 - Political ideologies
 - Political behavior
- 2 Understand how affective polarization harms democracy
- 3 Understand the concept of democratic backsliding

KEY TERMS

affective polarization people's increasing hostility toward their ideological opponents

canon the foundational texts of a given academic discipline

civil society all social and political organizations that exist outside the control of the state

cognitive dissonance emotional discomfort/mental stress caused by the clash between our beliefs and new information

- collective action** when groups of people work together to achieve a goal that an individual could not achieve alone
- critical political theory** seeks to expose, explain, and remedy the social systems that contribute to oppression in all of its many forms
- democratic deficit** the gap between people's idea of how democracy should function and their satisfaction with how it does function
- home truths** unpleasant truths – usually pointed out to us by someone else – that make us examine who we are, our faults, and our behavior
- legitimacy** people's voluntary acceptance of government
- misogyny** ingrained dislike of/disdain for and prejudice against women
- politics** who gets what, when, and how
- racism** discrimination against persons of another race based on the presumption that one race is superior to another
- social identity** a person's sense of self based on the groups (ethnic/racial, linguistic, religious, ideological, etc.) with which they identify
- universal truths** things that are true regardless of time or place

WHAT IS POLITICS?

Politics: Who Gets What, When, How is not simply the title of a classic book by political scientist Harold Lasswell (1936),¹ it is also what almost all political scientists will tell you is the basic definition of **politics**. Note that this definition (who gets what, when, how) doesn't mention government at all, and that's not an accident. Politics is, at its core, about resolving conflicts regardless of where those conflicts occur. You see political currents running throughout families, church congregations, friend groups, workplaces, schools, and (yes) government because they all involve human interaction, and human interaction often involves conflict. Politics is a standard feature (or bug?) of all human relationships. Here, of course, we focus on politics as related to government – this is, after all, a political science/government textbook – but remember: The dynamics of who gets what, when, how are at play everywhere.

Focusing on government and politics means that we need to start with the three main elements that are the foundations of politics:

- Political theory, which gives us ways to think about what qualifies as the “good life”
- Political ideology, which is a set of values/beliefs that structure a person's political worldview

- Political behavior, which is how people act in the political realm

Basically, in Part I of this book, you'll be learning about how we think politics *should* work (theory), how people are often motivated to engage with politics (ideology), how theory and ideology overlap, and what people actually do in the political realm (political behavior). This chapter provides a brief introduction to all of the above.

THE BASICS OF POLITICAL THEORY

When political scientists talk about political theory, we're typically talking about works that seek universal truths while attempting to determine the meaning of the "good life," which includes answering questions like the purpose of government, the definition of justice, or the meaning of citizenship (all which you'll read about in the next chapter). Political theorists use their observations to theorize about how the political world operates. Political theory is typically aimed at a narrow audience or scholars, politicians, political commentators, and policymakers and is meant to push readers to think about (and come to their own conclusions about) politics and political processes.

Typical political science textbooks start with ancient philosophers like Plato and Aristotle and end with Marx, with stops at such luminaries as Machiavelli, Locke, Rousseau, and Bentham along the way. All of these men are part of the **canon** (the foundational texts) of classical Western philosophical tradition (read: European). In their quests for **universal truths**, these men all put forth sweeping theories of human nature and the mechanics of society. Yet feminist theorist Mary Hawkesworth notes that as these political theorists make their generalizations about humans, society, and politics, they generally "conflate the experiences of some elite, white, European men with all of human experience."² It isn't that they all simply ignore people of color and women. As you'll see in [Box 1.1](#) and [Chapter 2](#), several of the "classic" works of political theory exclude women and people of color from the benefits of citizenship and pursuit of the good life. They deemed people of color less than human and justified the exclusion of women from the political sphere because they were "mere appendages to citizen man."³ The glaring **racism** and **misogyny** does not mean that we should "cancel" classic political theory. However, it does mean that we cannot treat the insights derived from the classics as universal truths. They may be truths for some of us, but they are certainly not truths for *all* of us.

BOX 1.1: JOHN LOCKE ON THE RIGHTS OF NATIVE AMERICANS, WOMEN, AND ENSLAVED PERSONS

Political philosopher John Locke (1632–1704) is often credited with founding the liberal school of political thought, which rejects absolute power and emphasizes the natural rights of man – European man, that is, since he considered Native Americans to be on the same level as “children, idiots, and the grossly illiterate.” On the subject of “man,” it is not always clear if Locke means *humanity* or *men*. Although he was more progressive on white women’s rights than many of his peers, his status as a proponent of women’s rights is highly contested. While he does indicate that all [white] people (arguably including women) are born equal, he does justify women’s subordination to their husbands’ wills on the basis that men are stronger and more able.⁴

As for his beliefs about enslaved peoples, those are made clear in the *Fundamental Constitutions of Carolina* (1669), the governing document for the then-British Carolina colony. Locke was one of the architects of the *Fundamental Constitutions*, which gave the enslaver “absolute power and authority over his Negro slaves.” It also recreated hereditary nobility for the eight Lord Proprietors of Carolina, among whom the lands taken from Native Americans were divided. The *Fundamental Constitutions* also recreated a form of hereditary serfdom that tied poor whites to the Lord Proprietors’ lands.

This “father of democracy” profited greatly from his support of enslavement and the theft of land from Native Americans. He owned stock in the Royal Africa Company, which controlled the British slave trade. He was also in line to become one of Carolina’s Lord Proprietors, should one of them die without a (male) heir.⁵ To be fair, Locke has defenders who say his writings were not a defense of slavery or stolen land in the Americas (see, for example Uzgalis, 2017).⁶ There’s more on Locke in [Chapter 2](#), so stay tuned.

Critical Political Theory and Home Truths

Critical theory is the direct outgrowth of what many marginalized political theorists regard as the racist, sexist, classist, and other biases embedded in the Lockean and other more conventional streams of political thought that make up the traditional political theory canon. **Critical political theory** encompasses many strands of political thought; what these have in common is that critical theorists seek to expose, explain, and remedy the social systems that contribute to oppression in all of its many forms. Critical theorists are less interested in *universal* truths and

more interested in *home* truths. On a personal level, **home truths** are unpleasant truths – usually pointed out to us by someone else – that make us examine who we are, our faults, and our behavior. Societal home truths are the unpleasant facts that force us to examine how our societies really function, how different groups are treated, and how we can be better. Just as personal home truths are pointed out to us by others, societal home truths are most often pointed out by outsiders to the system – people who have traditionally been marginalized. Two such groups, both of whom have been central to advancing critical political theory, are people of color and women. While the theories they advance, such as feminism and critical race theory, are not considered mainstream by many political scientists, they have nevertheless had considerable effects on how we think about politics.

Critical political theorists like Black feminist theorist bell hooks⁷ or critical race theorist Mari Matsuda examine structural inequality, meaning the ways in which society creates and maintains patriarchal and racist institutions that oppress women and people of color, and especially women of color. These theorists also identify ways in which we can reduce oppression and increase human freedom – they then challenge each of us to do something about it. This sort of call to action is a place where theory overlaps with ideology (there's a lot of overlap), so let's look at what political ideologies are and then I'll circle back around to how theory and ideology overlap by briefly examining feminism and critical race theory.

THE BASICS OF POLITICAL IDEOLOGIES

The word *ideology* and its derivatives have gotten a bad reputation. In common use, calling a policy *ideological* is shorthand for ill-conceived and extremist. The average person doesn't want to be viewed as ideological, since it implies that we don't think for ourselves. Calling someone an *ideolog* indicates that they are closed-minded and intolerant of other worldviews. Being *ideologically motivated* is such a slur that politicians regularly deny that their words, ideas, or positions are ideological.

We need to get past the negative connotation for a moment to look at what a political ideology actually is. Unfortunately, that isn't as easy as it sounds. As ideology expert David McClellan said, "Ideology is the most elusive concept in the whole of social science."⁸ As you'll see in [Chapter 3](#), the term is so contested that political scientists don't have an agreed-upon definition for it. Here, I will simply say that we'll be focused on *political* ideology, meaning a system of beliefs about how society should be governed. In other words, a political ideology is a system of beliefs about who *should* get what, when, and how.

Unlike political theories, which tend to sound educational or “objective,” political ideologies generally don’t have this façade. They are typically written in simple and targeted language that is designed to convince people that *this* ideology is the right one – the proper way to govern a society. As scholar Lyman Tower Sargent puts it, “An ideology provides the believer with a picture of the world both as it is and as it should be, and, in doing so, it organizes the tremendous complexity of the world into something fairly simple and understandable.”⁹ This simplicity is the allure of ideologies. Adopting an ideology guides people’s understanding of how society works, it tells them what they should support or oppose, it calls them to act on their beliefs, and it gives adherents a sense of community and common purpose.¹⁰ Ultimately, adopting a political ideology embeds you in a group of people who all share a similar worldview.

Divided We Fall

The sense of inclusion we feel when we adopt an ideological viewpoint may be why, despite negative feelings about ideology as a general concept, people regularly and enthusiastically embrace specific ideologies. Being part of an ideological group defines a person as a member (us) and everyone else as non-members (them). This us–them dynamic, where a person believes their group to be superior to the other group, contributes to the increase in people who have built their ideological commitment into their **social identity** – meaning they view their ideological belief system as a fundamental component of who they are as a person.¹¹ Indeed, some research indicates that people’s identification with a political ideology is as strong as their racial or religious identity.¹²

The increase in ideology-based identity is a factor in what we call **affective polarization** – meaning people’s increasing enmity toward their ideological opponents. Affective polarization is more than simple dislike or disagreement; it is active hostility rooted in the idea that your ideological opponents are not just wrong – they’re your enemy, traitors to the state, and all-around bad people. Sadly, it is becoming increasingly common for people to refuse to date, build friendships with, or even have meaningful discussions with those who don’t share their political ideology and opinions.¹³ This trend is problematic in democratic societies, which require willingness to compromise in order to function properly; affective polarization erodes trust in government and reduces government capacity to act. In short: High levels of affective polarization are *very* bad for democracy (see [Box 1.2](#)).

Even where people aren’t feeling outright hostility to the other side, they still have a hard time accepting other perspectives. For instance, if you have ever argued

BOX 1.2: AFFECTIVE POLARIZATION: A DANGER TO DEMOCRACY

For democracy to work, people have to be willing to talk about their differences and compromise on solutions. Increasing levels of affective polarization in long-standing democracies are troubling because, as political scientist Seymour Martin Lipset wrote, “Inherent in all democratic systems is the constant threat that the group conflicts which are democracy’s lifeblood may solidify to the point where they threaten to disintegrate society.”¹⁴ If people won’t even talk to their opponents, there’s no hope for compromise. Worse, as levels of affective polarization increase, trust in government decreases among people whose preferred party is not in government, but democratic satisfaction increases in people who voted for the winners.¹⁵ In turn, legislative productivity – getting things done – declines. Since people dislike their ideological opponents and have far different beliefs about the efficacy of government, the public doesn’t agree on enough to pressure parties to act.¹⁶ Given parties’ inaction, very little gets done, which the parties blame on their opponents – once more feeding into people’s dislike of their opponents and increasing affective polarization.

How do we get past this if people won’t even talk to each other? Perhaps, as Hobolt, Leeper, and Tilley suggest, “political scientists, and political theorists, should move beyond trying to understand how to overcome political disagreements, and focus more on how those disagreements can be sustained without yielding deleterious social consequences.”¹⁷ In other words: We have to figure out how to disagree while still respecting that the “other side” also wants what is best for the country – people have to recognize each other as fellow citizens rather than enemies.

politics with a particularly ideologically minded friend or relative, you’ve probably wondered why providing strong evidence to support your position failed to change the other person’s mind. There are many reasons, but chief among them is that people experience **cognitive dissonance** when confronted with evidence that contradicts their beliefs. Cognitive dissonance is emotional discomfort/mental stress caused by the clash between our beliefs and new information. As a species, we don’t do well with cognitive dissonance, and our brains are very good at figuring out how to restore mental harmony. Some research shows that we reject new evidence to reduce the discomfort of cognitive dissonance, while other research says that we actually may accept that the new evidence is true but we don’t allow it to change our minds.¹⁸

The Overlap between Theory and Ideology

Where things may get a little confusing with political theories and political ideologies is that there is considerable overlap between the two. In the earlier sections of this chapter, I summarized some of the major differences between political theory and political ideology. However, it is important for you to understand that this is a simplification we professors often use to make the distinctions between theory and ideology more accessible. The challenge is that separating the two as I’ve done above – and as we’ve done in [Chapters 2](#) and [3](#) – implies that theories and ideologies are neatly separable. While they may be separable in the abstract, that is often not the case in practice, where there is considerable overlap between the two.

It may help to use feminism and critical race theory (CRT) to show two ways that theory and ideology can overlap. In both cases, the ideology is firmly rooted in the theory. Activists use knowledge generated by theorists to tackle the many ways in which racism and sexism marginalize women and people of color.

Why use feminism and CRT as examples? Feminists and critical race theorists agree that sexism and racism intersect with other oppressive and exclusionary belief systems, such as homophobia and classism.¹⁹ Indeed, the theory that underlies this textbook, *intersectionality*, draws from both feminism and CRT. Thus, a (very) basic overview of each will be useful to you as the book progresses (see [Tables 1.1](#) and [1.2](#)). That said, keep in mind that, as with all political theories and ideologies, there are *many* different interpretations of both feminism and CRT. What is discussed here is less than even the tip of the iceberg (there are suggestions for further reading at the end of the chapter).

Table 1.1. Feminism

As a Theory	As an Ideology
Feminist theorists have demonstrated that the canon, the foundational texts, both omits women and justifies that omission by disparaging women’s capacity for political agency, free will, or reason, and even by questioning women’s right to exist in the public sphere. However, women cannot simply be added to the canon since the canon is largely predicated on the exclusion of women. Thus, the feminist approach isn’t to “add women and stir,” but rather to question how our understanding of politics changes when women are considered as full members of society. In so doing, feminist political theory gives us new ways to think about the political world. ²⁰ The knowledge created by feminist theorists drives calls to improve women’s standing in society.	Feminists seek to end the <i>patriarchy</i>, meaning the societal hierarchy that has historically given men the majority of power in society. As a group, however, feminists strongly disagree about how to achieve the goal. They do agree, however, on three central tenets of feminist ideology: • Gender is a significant and enduring fault line in society • This cleavage is highly unequal, with women disadvantaged by the patriarchy. • Political action is required to end the patriarchal norms embedded in society.²¹ Feminism has animated women’s movements around the world, including the suffrage, women’s liberation, and Women’s March movements.

Table 1.2. Critical Race Theory

As a Theory	As an Ideology
CRT grew out of both the realization that the US civil rights movement had stalled and the need to understand why. CRT theory demonstrates that not only is racism the default in society, it serves the interests of the dominant group.²² Because racism serves those interests, the dominant group has little incentive to tackle racism in meaningful ways unless doing so serves their interests. The classic example comes from Derrick Bell, who proposed that the US Supreme Court’s decision in <i>Brown v. Board of Education</i>, to racially integrate the US’s long-segregated education system, was less about Black equality than about serving the interests of elite Americans. Indeed, evidence from diplomatic cables and government archives shows that <i>Brown</i> was part of the US attempt to make itself more attractive to non-white countries during the Cold War.²³ CRT scholars are not content with knowledge production; the tenets of CRT demand that the knowledge be used in the fight for social justice.²⁴	Importantly, CRT indicates that because racism is both conscious and subconscious, ending overt racism won’t end societal inequalities. Rather than seeking an end to racism, activists work toward social justice and attempt to remedy historical and ongoing injustices. CRT theorists do so by exposing the racialization of society – the ways in which race is embedded in modern society; they then seek to rectify the harms caused by racialization. For example, CRT scholars have demonstrated tremendous racialized inequalities in the US criminal justice system, from unwarranted traffic stops of Black Americans to mass incarceration, which disproportionately affects the Black community. This knowledge animates the Black Lives Matter (BLM) movement, which started as a response to the senseless killing of Trayvon Martin and the acquittal of his killer. BLM is now a global Black liberation movement dedicated to “creating a world free of anti-Blackness, where every Black person has the social, economic, and political power to thrive.”²⁵

THE BASICS OF POLITICAL BEHAVIOR

As political behavior experts Russel J. Dalton and Hans-Dieter Klingemann put it, the major debates among political behavior scholars flow from the “claim that the wellspring of politics flows from the attitudes and behaviors of the ordinary citizen, and that the institutions of a democratic political process should be structured to respond to the citizenry.”²⁶ When you consider that it’s all about people and how they act in the political realm, and how political institutions respond to that, it makes sense that the study of political behavior encompasses a wide range of subjects. Political behavior scholars study everything from democratization to political communication to political culture to political participation. Since this textbook is intended for a survey course, there isn’t enough space to encompass the full breadth of political behavior. In this section we focus on political participation, including civil society, political parties, and voting.

Civil Society

In the previous section of this chapter, you read a lot about people and ideological groups. Ideological groups, however, are not formal organizations with members and meetings (because, as you’ll see in Chapter 3, ideologies and parties are not synonymous). Since people are social beings, we form all sorts of organizations – and

you have likely belonged to several. For example, you may belong to a house of worship (church, mosque, temple), a club or student organization (or many), a philanthropic/volunteer group, or a community association. Organizations like these make up what we call **civil society**, meaning all of the social and political organizations that exist outside the control of the state.

Civil society is an important factor in *pluralistic* societies, those in which many opposing and competing viewpoints are tolerated, if not welcomed. These many viewpoints often give rise to different types of civil society organizations, a variety of which are discussed in [Chapter 4](#). Here, I only mention two: interest groups and social movements. Both of these are forms of **collective action**, wherein groups of people work together to achieve a goal that an individual could not achieve alone.

INTEREST GROUPS

Interest groups are formally constituted organizations that seek to influence public policy related to their issue areas (the stuff they care about). Interest groups, like labor/trade unions, lobbyist groups, or issue-based groups (Greenpeace, Amnesty International, etc.), are well organized and work within the political system to achieve their goals (e.g., by lobbying legislatures or bureaucracies). But how effective are these groups at influencing policy? Do their efforts help or hurt democratic governance? These are questions that political behavior scholars regularly attempt to answer. In the interests of space, in [Box 1.3](#) we'll look at only two ways political scientists approach the question of interest groups and democracy: pluralism and corporatism.

BOX 1.3: INTEREST GROUPS AND DEMOCRATIC POLITICS

Pluralism is the theory that politics is driven by interest group competition, and through participation in interest groups, citizens have direct involvement in the making of the laws that govern them.²⁷ Importantly, pluralists argue that interest groups may have differing levels of power, but none is so powerful that it dominates the rest. In turn, advocates contend that since no single group dominates, all groups are able to participate and competition keeps the power of each interest group in check – that is, pluralism is a fair and beneficial system in a representative democracy. Critics, however, counter that competition doesn't actually constrain group power and that some groups become highly powerful and influential while other interests go almost unrepresented.²⁸ For example, critics of pluralism point to the National Rifle Association in the United States, whose

outsized political influence constrains gun control policies despite evidence that a majority of Americans support stricter gun control laws – 60 per cent in 2019, according to the Pew Research Center.²⁹

Corporatism is the theory that interest groups do compete, but they also co-operate both with each other and with government agencies to achieve their goals, thus giving interest groups a formal role in policymaking. Advocates point to corporatist tripartite (three-party) bargaining in European states like Germany or Norway, in which labor and wage policy is crafted in formal negotiations between the state, labor unions, and employer federations. Proponents argue that this system is beneficial to democracy because it ensures that the interests of workers/citizens and industry are given equal positions in the policymaking process and stimulates more deliberation regarding public interest.³⁰ In contrast, critics argue that corporatism only gives citizens influence if the interest groups truly represent citizen interests, yet these groups are typically controlled by elites who are fairly removed from their organizations' members and may or may not negotiate with members' interests in mind.³¹

SOCIAL MOVEMENTS

Social movements are groups of people who have come together around a particular issue, such as minority rights or the environment. In general, they are less formally organized and their goals may be less specific than those of interest groups – although interest groups often participate in social movements related to their area of interest (e.g., Greenpeace is a participant in the environmental movement). Social movements typically operate outside of the formal institutions of government. Indeed, social movements challenge formal institutions through continued protest and activism on behalf of the movement's cause.

Social movement scholars attempt to answer a wide range of questions, including (but not limited to) the conditions under which movements arise, why people are motivated to join movements, how movements affect and are affected by the political environment in a given state, and when and to what extent social movements succeed in achieving their goals.

The expansion of democratic practices within societies has been a frequent topic of interest for scholars. The limited nature of early democracy makes democratization (the process of becoming a democratic state) a good example of how social movements can transform society. As social movements' expert Ruud Koopmans points out, social movements have expanded democracy in at least two ways: who

can vote (suffrage) and which issues matter to politicians (the political agenda).³² First, it's important to remember that in the initial stages of democracy, suffrage was quite limited; men without property, women, and minorities were typically excluded from the voting booth. Suffrage was only extended to those groups after sustained campaigns by labor, women's, and civil rights movements, respectively. Second, government tends to maintain the status quo rather than seek out new issues to tackle. Social movements are often responsible for putting new issues on the political agenda. Take, for example, environmental protection. The environment was not considered an appropriate subject for government action until social movements around the world agitated for better regulation of pollution, recycling programs, and a host of other environmental conservation policies.

While social movements do not always spawn political parties, the environmental movement of the 1960s and 1970s led to the development of Green parties throughout Western Europe.³³ Green parties were primarily created to advocate for environmental protection and conservation, but they also typically advocate for social justice policies that decrease oppression and discrimination. Green parties are related to both the environmental movement and to environmentally focused interest groups, but each of the three (party/movement/group) has its own role to play in terms of political participation. Interest groups work within the formal structures of government via lobbying and partnerships, social movements work outside of those structures via protest, and parties work (via campaigns and elections) to become members of government and represent the interests of their constituents.

Parties, Voting, and Backsliding

In a direct democracy, each citizen would be required to participate in decision making by voting on every law adopted by the state. As you might suppose, this could easily become a very messy enterprise. Instead, democratic states are (to a greater or lesser extent) representative democracies.³⁴ In a representative democracy, citizens delegate decision making to elected officials whose job it is (ostensibly) to represent the interests of their constituents. Their job is to represent the interests of their constituents, but how do they know what those interests are? How do constituents make clear what it is they want? Those are complex questions with complex answers. One part of the answer is *political parties*.

POLITICAL PARTIES

While there are many types and definitions of political parties, for our purposes they are groups that participate in elections with the goal of acquiring power to

influence government outcomes (policies). If they simply sought to influence public policies, they would just be interest groups; it is the contesting of elections that separates the two.³⁵

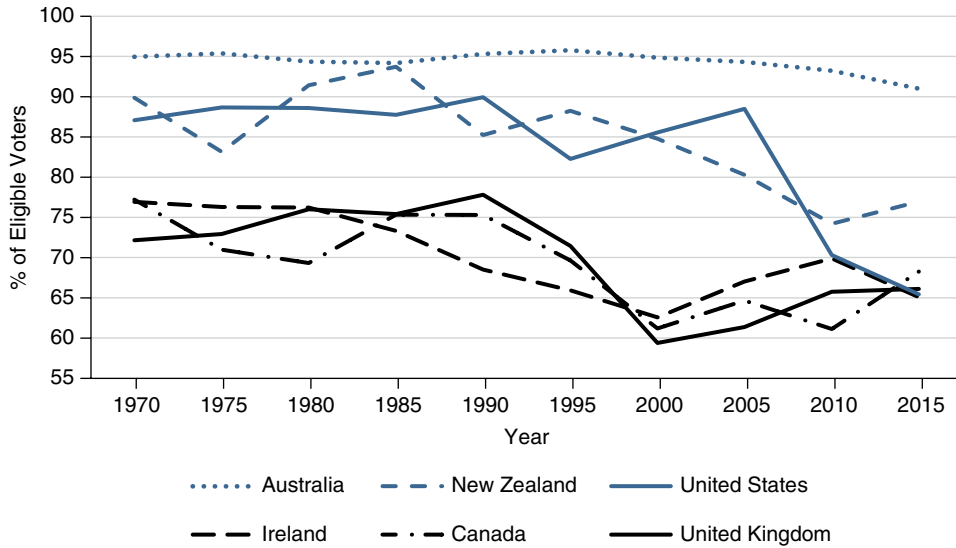
While many have disparaged parties – James Madison famously sneered at what he called “factions,” warning that they were dangerous to democracy – almost every democratic state has some sort of organized political party system. Why are parties ubiquitous in democratic societies? Because parties are what we call *linkage institutions*. Simply put, they are the primary way in which citizens connect with the state. Less simply put, parties are the primary linkages in the following ways:³⁶

- Campaigns: recruiting candidates and putting them forth for office
- Elections: motivating citizen interest in the election and encouraging them to vote
- Interest aggregation: bringing together the interests of a group of citizens in a (coherent) policy program
- Representation: connecting voter policy preferences with the policymaking process
- Policy outcomes: delivering on the policy promises made while campaigning

As you can see, parties have tremendous influence throughout the political process. Without them, it would be quite difficult to hold elections or govern. First, parties simplify the choices available to voters by providing heuristics (mental shortcuts) that allow voters to make choices without having to work too hard at it – the party label itself tells people much of what they need to know about what/for whom they are voting. Returning to the Green parties example, when voters see the Green Party label, voters know that the basic policy program centers on environmental protection and social justice, thus for many voters there is no need to do further research. Second, parties recruit and train candidates, thus helping elections run more smoothly. Finally, when parties win, they turn candidates into elected representatives and through those representatives, parties structure the work of government as they attempt to implement the policy program for which their constituents voted.

VOTER TURNOUT

At least that’s how representative democracy should work – citizens’ interests (as expressed by their votes) should drive the work of government. If it were that straightforward, however, voter turnout – which is in decline in long-established

Figure 1.1. Voter Turnout in Anglo-American States, 1970–2019

Source: Data from the Institute for Democracy and Electoral Assistance (IDEA) Voter Turnout Database, 2020.
 Note: Chart shows parliamentary election turnout for the election closest to the year listed for all states except the United States. US data are for the presidential election closest to the year listed.

democracies – might look a lot different.³⁷ Figure 1.1 shows the voter turnout decline in Anglo-American states. Note that turnout has decreased even in Australia, where voting is compulsory.

Because voting is a central feature of democracy, scholars have been studying voting behavior for decades. Among the most important questions are who votes and why. In established democracies, age and education are both dominant factors in voter turnout. The older and better educated, the more likely a person is to vote.³⁸ Older people may be more inclined to vote because of a sense of civic duty, a greater stake in the system (they are more likely to own property or have children, for example), and they likely pay more attention to politics. The latter, paying more attention, likely factors into the education gap in voting as well – the better informed, the more likely a person is to vote. Education also matters because the more educated tend to be involved in more civil society organizations, which fosters political interest and learning.

Consider the following, however:

- 1 The median age in Western countries is increasing (there are more old and middle-aged people than young people).

- 2 There have been significant increases in the number of people getting university degrees.
- 3 Voter turnout is declining.

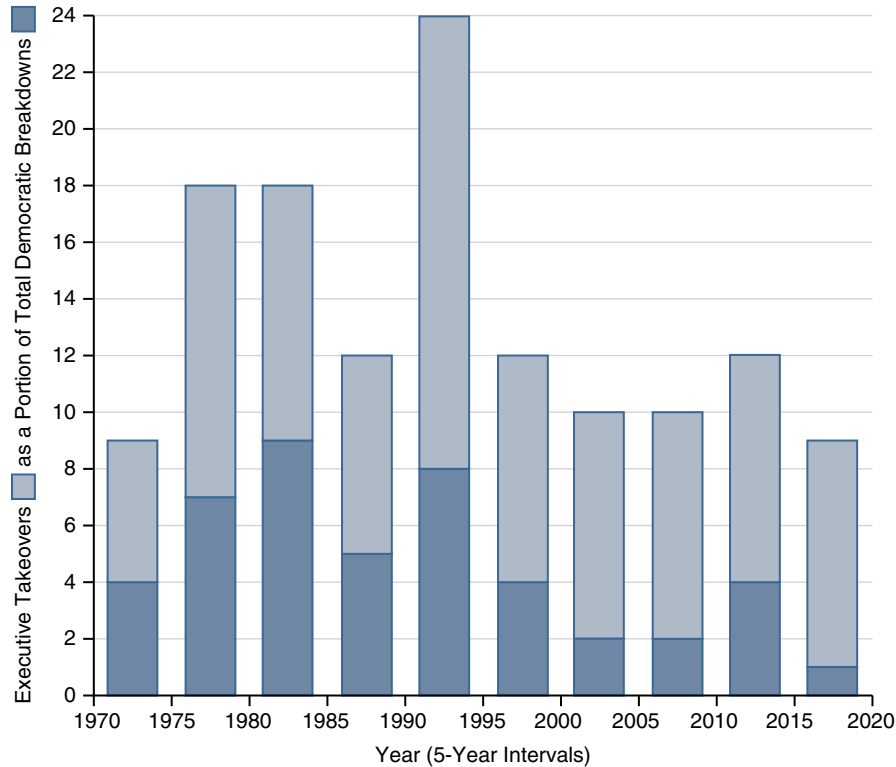
If there are larger numbers of older and better educated people, why is voter turnout declining? In short: We are not sure. Political scientists have explored institutional, demographic, and attitudinal hypotheses to attempt to answer this question, yet most answers have been found to be lacking.³⁹

First, the institutional hypotheses fall apart given that the decline is fairly steady across most established democracies, regardless of their institutional setup (electoral systems, party systems, etc.). Second, the demographic explanation indicates that voter turnout should decline gradually as older generations die off and less-interested generations take their place; however, the decline has not been gradual – it took a statistically significant downward turn starting in 1980. However, there is evidence that it is among younger generations where turnout is weakest.⁴⁰ This is where the attitudinal hypothesis comes into play. Scholars hypothesize that the decrease in voting is related to a decline in citizens' belief that (1) voting is a civic duty and (2) voting matters; it may be that this decline is largest among younger citizens. The attitudinal hypothesis may have some validity. As experts Marc Hooghe and Anna Kern put it, "Citizens of liberal democracies may indeed ... have stopped believing that they have a civic duty to take part in elections."⁴¹ However, this answer is not definitive, and it leads to more questions: Why 1980? Why are younger people less likely to see voting as a civic duty? Why are people now less likely to think their vote matters? Of course, you may be wondering if the decrease in voter turnout even matters; democratic states are still functioning, after all.

DEMOCRATIC BACKSLIDING

From a normative perspective – how we think democracy should ideally work – turnout matters quite a lot. From the ideal perspective, high participation is an important part of a well-functioning democracy. Theoretically, high turnout means that more citizens have used their vote to make their preferences known and hold elected officials accountable, thus increasing people's belief in government **legitimacy**, meaning their voluntary acceptance of government.

Also theoretically, when turnout is low it may undermine people's confidence in both government legitimacy and the results of the election: They may feel that the election results themselves are illegitimate. Low turnout may also indicate a growing **democratic deficit**, or the gap between people's idea of how democracy

Figure 1.2. Executive Takeovers and Democratic Breakdowns, 1973–2018

Source: Created using data from Milan W. Svoblik, "Polarization versus Democracy," *Journal of Democracy* 30, no. 3 (2019): 22.

should function and their satisfaction with how it does function.⁴² If the democratic deficit is high, people's dissatisfaction may drive them away from the polls. However, the research into voter turnout and satisfaction provides mixed results. While some studies demonstrate a voter turnout–dissatisfaction link, others find low voter turnout instead means that people are basically satisfied with how their state is functioning.⁴³ Why is it difficult to arrive at a definitive answer about how satisfied people are with democratic governance? Because questions of people's trust in government and feelings of political efficacy (feeling that your participation matters) are all tangled up with their satisfaction levels.

It is important that we keep trying to understand people's attitudes toward democracy, however, given global concerns about *democratic backsliding*. Backsliding is what happens when governments in democratic states undermine or eliminate institutions and rules that sustain democracy. It is easier to undermine

democratic institutions, particularly under the guise of “reform,” when people are dissatisfied with them. A good example of backsliding is *executive takeover*, in which an elected authoritarian-leaning leader erodes democratic institutions and consolidates power. In modern democracies, executive takeovers do not typically look like Hitler’s executive takeover in Germany – he moved swiftly and boldly to gut Germany’s fledgling democracy. Today, executive takeovers are slow; leaders gradually erode democratic institutions so carefully that their actions may lead to the total breakdown of democracy. Indeed, political scientist Milan Svoblik has found that executive takeover leading to democratic breakdown has been increasing since the end of the Cold War, as shown in [Figure 1.2](#);⁴⁴ this is what happened in Venezuela, which was once a vibrant (if imperfect) democracy (see [Box 1.4](#)).

BOX 1.4: DEMOCRATIC BACKSLIDING IN VENEZUELA

Venezuela could be called the poster child of democratic backsliding, as political scientists Stephen Levitsky and Daniel Ziblatt detail in the best-selling book *How Democracies Die*.⁴⁵ Democratic governance flourished in Venezuela from 1958 through the 1970s and 1980s, when much of the region was in the grip of military dictatorships, and into the 1990s. It wasn’t all smooth sailing, though – in the late 1980s and early 1990s oil prices tanked, poverty doubled, the economy stagnated, and ordinary Venezuelans became fed up with the status quo. When Venezuelans elected Hugo Chávez as president in 1998, they expected him to shake up the system and use the state’s oil wealth to reduce poverty and inequality. In the early years of his presidency, Chávez followed through on his campaign promises, implementing important economic and social welfare programs that benefited the poor (although these became highly *clientelistic*, meaning the resources were often delivered based on political grounds rather than technical reasons).⁴⁶ But by 2003–4, his authoritarian tendencies were starting to show – stalling a recall election (it would have removed him from office), then packing the Supreme Court with his supporters, and blacklisting anyone who supported the recall. In 2006, things took an even sharper authoritarian turn when Chávez had high-profile opponents arrested or exiled and eliminated term limits so that he could serve as many terms as he liked. Chávez continued chipping away at Venezuela’s democratic institutions until his death in 2013, and his hand-picked successor, Nicolas Maduro, picked up where Chávez left off.⁴⁷ By 2017, all pretense of democracy was gone; Venezuela had completed its backslide into full-fledged authoritarian rule.

The specter of democratic backsliding hangs over much of the democratic world, as evidenced by the popularity of elected authoritarian-leaning leaders in supposedly democratic states. Remember: Democratic backsliding isn't a coup d'état in which outsiders take over by force. Backsliding is planned and carried out by elected incumbents. Elected leaders like Viktor Orbán in Hungary, Rafael Correa in Ecuador, and Recep Tayyip Erdoğan in Turkey have leveraged people's frustrations with their states' social problems (immigration, the economy, etc.) to win power and subsequently weaken democratic institutions.⁴⁸

Keep in mind that constitutions cannot cover all contingencies, so democratic societies develop norms – unwritten but widely understood rules – that address regularly occurring contingencies. One of the ways politicians undermine democracy is by demolishing these norms; they know they can get away with it from a legal perspective because the rules are informal and unwritten. For example, Levitsky and Ziblatt note one of the long-standing norms in American politics was *institutional forbearance* – the unwritten rule that politicians won't use extreme tactics that are technically legal if using them violates the spirit of the law.⁴⁹ However, the demolition of the institutional forbearance norm, particularly in the US Congress, over the past few decades has helped to destroy another important American norm: *mutual toleration*. This is the idea that, although you don't *agree* with (or even like) your political rivals, you accept that they were legitimately elected and have the right to govern.⁵⁰ The elimination of these norms adds to citizens' perceptions that the "other side" is the problem; in other words, destroying these norms has helped to foster greater affective polarization.

Putting the Pieces Together: Affective Polarization, Voting, and Democratic Backsliding

Earlier in this chapter, you read about *affective polarization*, or people's outright hostility toward their political opponents. It turns out that as societies become more polarized, it becomes easier for authoritarian-leaning leaders to undermine democracy – even in states where citizens profess high levels of support for democracy, like the United States. Unfortunately, the voting behaviors of those citizens increasingly indicate that their support for democracy is limited by polarization.

In states with increasing levels of affective polarization, the shrinking pool of centrist voters means that there are fewer voters who are willing to put their principles before their partisan or policy preferences. When the choice is between (1) voting for an authoritarian-leaning politician that appeals to their interests and (2) a democratic-leaning politician whose platform is less appealing, it is

democratic principles that are more likely to be sacrificed. Indeed, Svobik found that in states as diverse as the United States, Turkey, and Venezuela, “Ordinary people are willing to trade off democratic principles for partisan interests” and “voters are reluctant to punish politicians for disregarding democratic principles when doing so requires abandoning one’s favored party or policies.”⁵¹ In short, when it’s their authoritarian candidate, large portions of the electorate will look the other way. They know they can leverage affective polarization, so aspiring authoritarians subvert democracy by pitting citizens against each other, heightening their animosity toward each other until it is unthinkable to vote for the “other side” even in the face of growing authoritarianism. It’s classic divide-and-conquer. Understanding the tactic enables you to fight against democratic backsliding.

What can you do? Here, I give you a few of historian Timothy Snyder’s 20 lessons for avoiding authoritarianism.⁵² The first is to “not obey in advance.” By this, he means do not give your allegiance to candidates or parties that have already declared authoritarian intent. Use your vote to support candidates that support democracy. Second, defend a democratic institution – maybe it’s the press, the legislature, the courts – it doesn’t matter which one you pick, just pick one and defend it from undemocratic practices. Among his other lessons are to “believe in truth,” “investigate,” and “learn from others in other countries”; in other words, think critically, don’t believe propaganda blindly, and seek outside perspectives. And finally, I leave you with one last lesson from Professor Snyder: “make eye contact and small talk.” While this may seem trivial, it is people’s increasing unwillingness to talk to each other and breach our divides that gives aspiring authoritarians the opening they need to weaken democracy. Each of us, no matter what our ideological bent, can help safeguard democracy. The question is whether we will all do so.

At the end of this book there is an appendix with more ideas for how you can get involved and safeguard democracy.

SUMMARY

- The basic definition of politics is *who gets what, when, how*.
- The foundations of politics are the following:
 - Political theory, which gives us ways to think about what qualifies as the “good life”
 - Political ideology, which is a set of values/beliefs that structure a person’s political worldview
 - Political behavior, which is how people act in the political realm

- Many of the foundational political theory texts are riddled with racism, sexism, classism, and other biases.
 - Critical theory, largely developed by scholars from marginalized groups, pushes back against the canon, exposing different forms of structural injustice and proposing remedies to those injustices. Critical race theory and feminism are two examples of critical theory.
- Political ideology is a controversial concept and many people view it negatively. However, people frequently adopt ideological outlooks that structure their view of how the world works. It is increasingly common for people to view their political worldview as part of their identity, just as people view ethnicity or religion as part of their identity.
 - The more strongly people identify with an ideology, the more likely they are to be actively hostile to people with other ideological viewpoints, a problem known as *affective polarization*.
- Although presented separately, there is considerable overlap between political theory and ideology. The two cannot be as easily separated either in practice or in theory.
- Civil society, the organizations outside the control of government, is essential to a functioning democracy. Among the many types of organizations are interest groups, which work inside the formal institutions of government in their quest to affect public policy, and social movements, which are less-formal groups that have come together around a particular issue and work outside the formal institutions of government (e.g., through protest).
- Political parties provide the primary link between citizens and the state. Parties are involved in every stage of the political process, from candidate recruitment to policy outcomes.
- While even some authoritarian regimes have elections (e.g., North Korea), it is free and fair elections that are a hallmark of democratic governance. Voter turnout is falling in the oldest democracies; we cannot be sure if this is a sign that people are satisfied with their governments or if they are not.
- Democratic backsliding happens when governments in democratic states undermine or eliminate institutions and rules that sustain democracy. Citizens have shown that when the authoritarian-leaning leader comes from “their side” of the political divide, they are more likely to ignore or forgive actions that undermine democracy. Thus, affective polarization helps to enable democratic backsliding.
 - Knowing the tactics enables you to fight against efforts to undermine democracy.

CONCLUDING QUESTIONS

- 1 What types of politics do you see in your daily life?
- 2 Why does critical theory exist? What are these theorists criticizing and why?
- 3 Affective polarization. Discuss.
- 4 Democratic deficit is the difference between the perception of how democracy is and the idea of what it should be. Thinking about your society, is there a democratic deficit? If so, what seems to be driving it?
- 5 Why are political scientists and democracy advocates so concerned about democratic backsliding?

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RESOURCES AND SUGGESTIONS FOR FURTHER READING

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